CRIO

A framework for getting real value from AI conversations

A CoachBay framework

> There is a moment that happens when you use AI well on a real problem. You have been sitting with something for days. A decision you cannot quite land. A challenge that keeps circling back. You open AI, structure the conversation properly, and within ten minutes you are looking at angles you had not considered before.

That is what CRIO gives you. Not just a better answer. Hope.

The shift is simple but significant. Most people ask: how can I do this? CRIO teaches you to ask: how can AI help me do this? That one change in framing opens up a completely different kind of conversation.

The Four Components

C — Context

Set the scene before you ask for anything. Tell AI what is really going on, not just the surface request. What is the situation? Why does it matter? Who is involved? What constraints are you working within? The more honest and specific you are here, the more useful everything that follows will be. AI can only work with what you give it. Vague context produces vague output.

In plain terms: What is going on, why does it matter, and what does AI need to understand before it can help?

R — Role

Tell AI who to be. Not what to do yet, but whose perspective to bring. A skeptical CFO. An executive coach. A competitor's CEO. A board advisor who genuinely wants you to succeed but will not let you fool yourself. The role shapes everything: the tone, the angle, the level of challenge. A junior assistant gives you safe answers. A tough board member gives you the pushback you actually need.

In plain terms: Answer this as if you were a specific expert whose perspective would be most useful to me right now.

I — Interview

Ask AI to slow down before it responds. Tell it to interview you with three questions, one at a time, before it gives you anything. This is the step most people skip, and it is the most important one. Without it, AI guesses at your situation and produces something generic. With it, AI builds a real understanding of your specific context before it says anything useful. Three questions is the right number. Too few and AI does not have enough. Too many and it starts to loop.

In plain terms: Before you respond, ask me three questions, one at a time, to make sure you fully understand my situation.

O — Output

Now tell AI exactly what you want back. Not a general ask. A specific, concrete deliverable that you could actually use. Options with trade-offs. A decision memo. Three possible approaches with a recommendation. A first draft of the communication. A list of the assumptions you should pressure-test before you commit. The more precise your output request, the more usable the result. Vague asks produce vague answers.

In plain terms: Here is exactly what I want you to produce for me.

A Worked Example

A leader is preparing to restructure their team and is not sure how to communicate it.

Context:
I am the Managing Director of a 40-person marketing agency. We are about to restructure our team, moving from a department-based model to client-focused pods. Three people will be made redundant. Two others will move into new roles they did not ask for. I need to communicate this to the team next Friday. I have done restructures before and they have not always landed well. Trust in leadership is fragile right now.

Role:
Act as an organizational psychologist who specializes in helping leaders communicate difficult change with honesty and empathy.

Interview:
Before you give me anything, ask me three questions to understand the deeper context. Ask me one question at a time.

Output:
Once you have enough context, give me a suggested structure for the all-hands communication, the three things I must say to maintain trust, and the one thing I should avoid saying even if it feels reassuring.

That prompt takes about three minutes to write. What comes back will be more useful than most things a leader could produce on their own in an hour.

The Shift to Remember

Every time you sit down with a problem, the old question is:
how can I do this?
The new question is:
how can AI help me do this?

It sounds small. It is not.

Want to bring CRIO into your leadership team?
Tomas Bay runs hands-on workshops that go from concept to real workflows in a single session.
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